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SOUTHERN STYLE
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THE CLARION-LEDGER ■ JACKSON, MISSISSIPPI

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MONDAY, FEBRUARY 9, 1998



GARY PETTUS
TV & Radio Columnist
The Clarion-Ledger

Humans fair game, but lay off the meat and potatoes

In this country, you cannot be sued for saying bad things about the President of the United States, any other elected official or most guests on *The Jerry Springer Show*.

But in Mississippi and some other states you can be sued for slandering a United States ch*cken.

For instance, if I were to say that lately Bill Clinton has been running around like a chicken with his head cut off, I could not be sued by Bill Clinton.

But if I were to say instead that a ch*cken with its head cut off sure does remind me of Bill Clinton, I could quite possibly be sued by poultry processors, and a smart ch*cken lawyer might make mincem*at out of me on the stand.

And, if my remarks somehow caused wing prices to drop to a 10-year low, I certainly would have laid an *gg.

Lord knows, I'd never willfully damage the reputation of a ch*cken, even one with its h**d cut off. Because, in spite of the First Amendment, Mississippi is one of 13 states with a law that protects perishable food products from false and disparaging statements. Offenders could be forced to pay actual and punitive damages.

And, unlike media star Oprah Winfrey, I don't have $10.3 million b*cks.

That's about how much Texas cattlemen want in a suit they've brought against her, her production company and a vegetarian.

Bad-mouthing beef

In April 1996, the cattlemen say, a vegetarian activist with the unfortunate (for him) name of Howard Lyman went on Oprah's TV show and maliciously maligned beef, roast beef, chuck roast, short ribs, hamburger, corned beef, corned Willie, chipped beef, salt beef, jerky, charqui, pastrami, beef Wellington, beef extract, beefcake, beef tea, the entire beef family, but not Spam.

The cattlemen say that when Lyman, a former cattle rancher, expressed his opinion that mad c*w disease *could* occur in the United States, as it has in England, his statements weren't based on facts.

They also say that because Oprah swore off beef during the show, her formidable influence with the American public caused already slumping beef prices to drop to a 10-year low. Madder than a wet h*n, they're suing Oprah based on Texas law, which apparently protects cows from insults but not born-again Christians from death by lethal injection.

Personally, I believe that legislators in any state who made it illegal to libel Limburger have bought themselves a p*g in a poke. Never mind that under such a law then-President B*sh could have been sued for bad-mouthing broc*li.

Or that then-Vice President Dan Qua*le could have been sued for that tragic misspelling incident, especially if his mistake had helped push already slumping p*tato prices to a 10-year low. Under the law, ignorance is no excuse, as Qua*le proved time and again.

Slander by association?

What does concern me is that when the Texas cattlemen call the vegetarian activist a liar, that allegation may, under the law and by association, be construed as an attack on innocent vegetables themselves and therefore become actionable under food product anti-defamation statutes, including Mississippi's, which may be paraphrased thus: "He who steals my purse steals trash, but he who steals the good name of my leek will get his punts sued off."

The law is not exactly clear on this point, but surely somewhere in this state there's an attorney prepared to seek justice for a litigious sweet pea or some such ("offshore workers, divorce, wrongful death, parsnips").

Surely, there is one out there who will take on those cattlemen in Texas, who have, in effect, pooh-poohed our pawpaws, snickered at our soybeans, taunted our tomatoes and affronted our tender alfalfa.

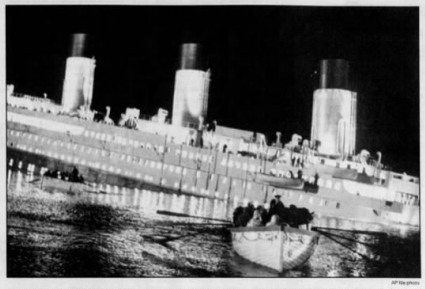
Even more surely, this country is slowly going n*ts, and our regard for freedom has slumped to a 10-year low.

■

Gary Pettus' column appears on Wednesday. To contact him, call 961-7037. Tomorrow: Sherry Lucas.

LIFESTYLE

TITANIC SAILS AGAIN



As the ship sinks, lifeboats are rowed away in a scene from *Titanic*, the $200 million movie directed by James Cameron which has earned more than $300 million so far at the box office and churned interest in the real-life tragedy.









The popularity of the hit movie *Titanic* has sparked interest in the subject, driving up sales and rentals of related books and videos.

Photos by John Severson

■ Hit movie generates wave of popularity for all things related to doomed ship

By Neill Luter Floyd
Clarion-Ledger Staff Writer

Kathy Brookshire's students have always studied the sinking of the Titanic, but they're more interested this year than ever.

"Since the movie has come out, it's their only thought," said Brookshire, who teaches third-graders in the gifted program at Poplar Springs Elementary in Meridian.

Brookshire recently asked Robert D. Ballard, the explorer who in 1985 discovered the remains of the luxury liner that sank in the North Atlantic Ocean in 1912, for an autograph after he spoke Jan. 27 in Jackson.

"The Titanic is a riveting story that has captured every generation," said Ballard of Olde Lyme, Conn., in town to launch The JASON Program of student ocean exploration.

Thanks to James Cameron's *Titanic*, interest in things Titanic is billowing like a tidal wave.

Call 1-800-TITANIC (1-800-848-2642), and you can buy a piece of coal ($10) salvaged from the wreck. The J. Peterman Company, a privately owned mail-order and retail company in Lexington, Ky., has sold a boatload of costumes and props from the movie and plans to offer more in catalogs due in March, April and September.

Want to step back in history? You can pretend you're a British agent aboard the ship by playing *Titanic Adventure Out of Time*, a CD-ROM title from CyberFlix of Knoxville, Tenn.

Cruise the Internet, and you can download a screensaver featuring an image of Leonardo DeCaprio and Kate Winslet, stars of the movie.

"Interest has never been this high," said Edward S. Kanuda of Indian Springs, Mass., founder and president of the Titanic Historical Society that's gained 1,000 new members in the last two months.

"We usually have something similar every year when we hold a convention, but it goes away after a couple of days. This has been ongoing since Dec. 19, when the movie came out."

The movie, which won Golden Globe awards for best dramatic picture, best director and best original score and song, is expected to play another month in Jackson. It's on at Northpark 14 in Ridgeland, Clinton 10 in Clinton and Parkway Place 10 in Flowood.

"It'll stay here as long as it does well," said Stan Booth, director of training for United Artists Theaters.

"It did $26 million last weekend and reached the $300 million mark for total gross on the picture. Supposedly, it's the seventh all-time biggest-grossing picture."

"We're still having sell-out crowds," said Don Davis of Kenner, La., district manager for the 36 United Artists Theaters in Mississippi and Louisiana.

The emotion the movie evokes leads Labrone Johnson of Jackson, who works

See TITANIC, 2D



Ballard

COMPUTERS

New type of virus attacks popular Microsoft Excel

From Wire Service Reports

A new family of computer viruses appears to be on the loose.

Anti-virus software developer Network Associates (formerly McAfee) says it has identified a completely new type of virus in a computer in France — the first identified Formula Infector, a virus that spreads through formulas in spreadsheets.

The "pxix.x" virus attacks Microsoft Excel, the most popular spreadsheet program, by removing the toolbar and forcing the user to close the worksheet without saving data, thereby losing it. The virus renames the file "Pxix en fin," French for "Peace at last."

"This is a threat," says Gene Hodges of Network Associates' anti-virus team. Copycats could follow because "it's easy to write, and it attacks a popular application."

Past Excel viruses were largely "macro viruses," which replicate and spread when automatic functions are executed, such as opening files or pressing certain keys.

The new Formula Infectors activate when a user makes a simple calculation.

Network Associates has posted an update to its antivirus software, BetaScan.zip, which will identify and kill the virus. It is available at beta.mcafee.com/public/datafiles.

Anti-virus researcher Steve Trilling of Symantec says that company also has isolated the virus and is working on a solution, which will be posted soon at www.symantec.com.

For Black History Month

As the Internet grows, it increasingly is fostering networks of like-minded people, whether for practical ends like commerce or for broader goals such as building political communities. An array of Web sites attempts to help African Americans on both levels — from employment opportunities to culture and literature.

One place to start is EverythingBlack (www.everythingblack.com), a sort of mega-mall home page. It displays 12 broad categories — from arts and humanities to business, entertainment and travel — that offer links to hundreds of Web sites, including African-American community news outlets all over the country.

There are numerous specialized sites, too. Mosaicbooks.com/The Black Literary Showcase (www.mosaicbooks.com), an affiliate of online bookstore Amazon.com, features summaries and recommendations on current black and Hispanic literature. Black Facts Online (www.blackfacts.com) is a fledgling database/search engine that aspires to be "Your Internet Resource of Black History Information." Black Urban Professionals Online (www.buppie.com) provides parenting tips, a resume databank, guidance on personal finance, and professional and social calendars. The Black Collegian Online (www.black-collegian.com) offers career advice and a state-by-state job database. And that's just a smattering.

TOMORROW



Neighborhood stories

If our neighborhoods could talk . . . Maybe they can. Voices of Jackson: An Oral History of Our Neighborhoods is a series of workshops that can give people the tools to collect the background, heritage and texture of their surroundings. We'll have details in Southern Style Tuesday.

CUTTING EDGE



New cards trade flowery poetry for conversational prose

From Wire Service and Trade Reports

New in greeting card racks this Valentine's season are Coffeehouse valentines from American Greetings.

The new line (left) has a whimsical, hand-made look and casual, conversational messages. The cards are especially popular with baby boomers and Generation X, the company says.

The one pictured here says "As the years go by, as our dreams come true . . . You're still the only one for me. Happy Valentine's Day with love."

Defining our time

What's the dictionary term for someone 35 to 45 years old who hangs onto the trappings of youth culture?

An "adultescent," which the prestigious Oxford English Dictionary is considering including in its new edition.

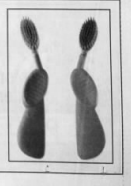
Over at the Webster's New World Dictionary, they're considering the word "nemdetwe." That's a person who's middlebrow, but in a fashionable way.

Look behind you!

To help prevent automobile accidents, Sense Technologies offers the Guardian, a microwave sensor device that warns drivers of objects behind them ($199 installed, expected to be available this spring). The circuitry fits into the area at the back of the vehicle by the license plate, and a sensor usually sits in the rear shelf of the vehicle. A beep warns that an object is behind the vehicle and depending on how close the object is, a different color light lights up. The device is aimed at preventing backing-up accidents.

Easy does it

The new Scuba-Z toothbrushes (right), available in a wide range of Euro-influenced colors, feature a flexible neoprene rubber neck and handle that absorb excess hand pressure during brushing. This is designed to lower force on the gum line, which results in a light-pressure, non-traumatic cleaning and massage for sensitive tissue.



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